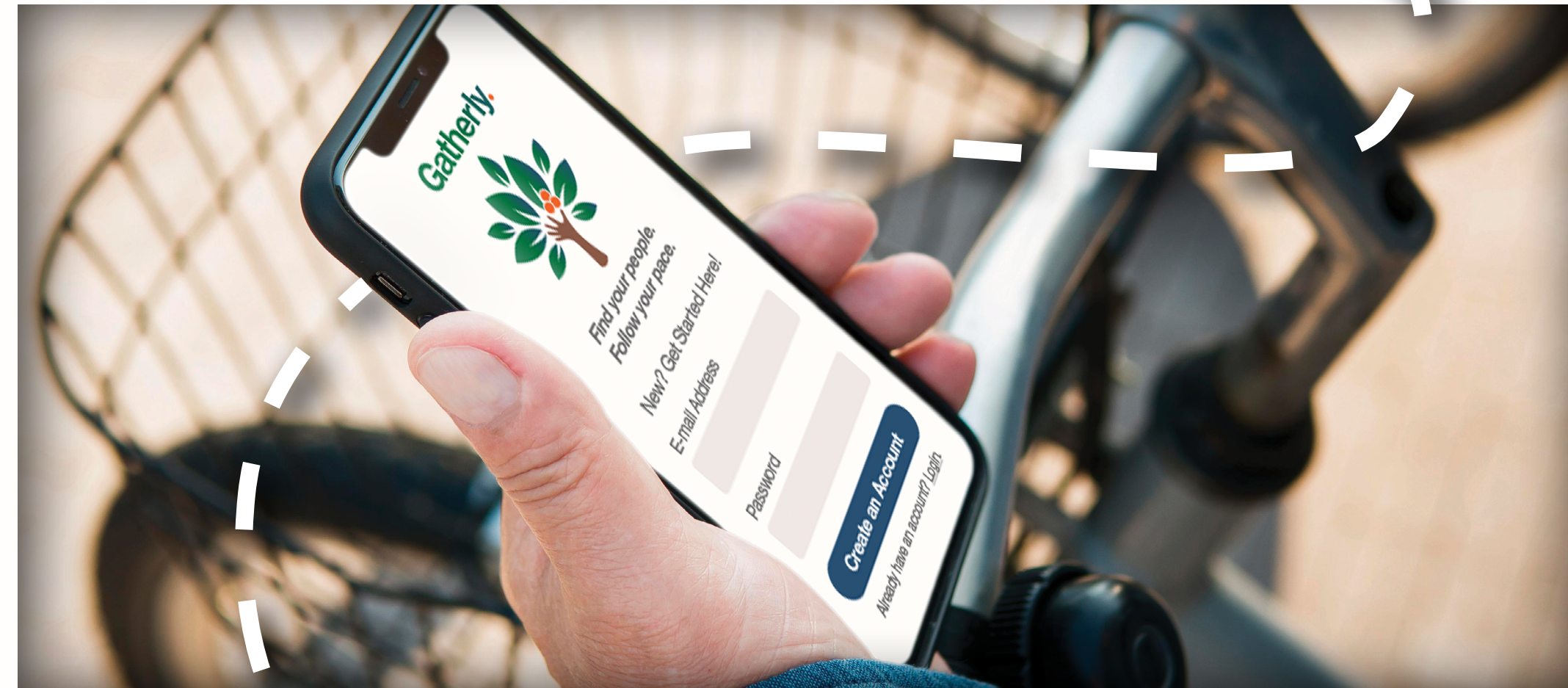




Gatherly.

A New Social Media App to Combat FOMO

Miah Green

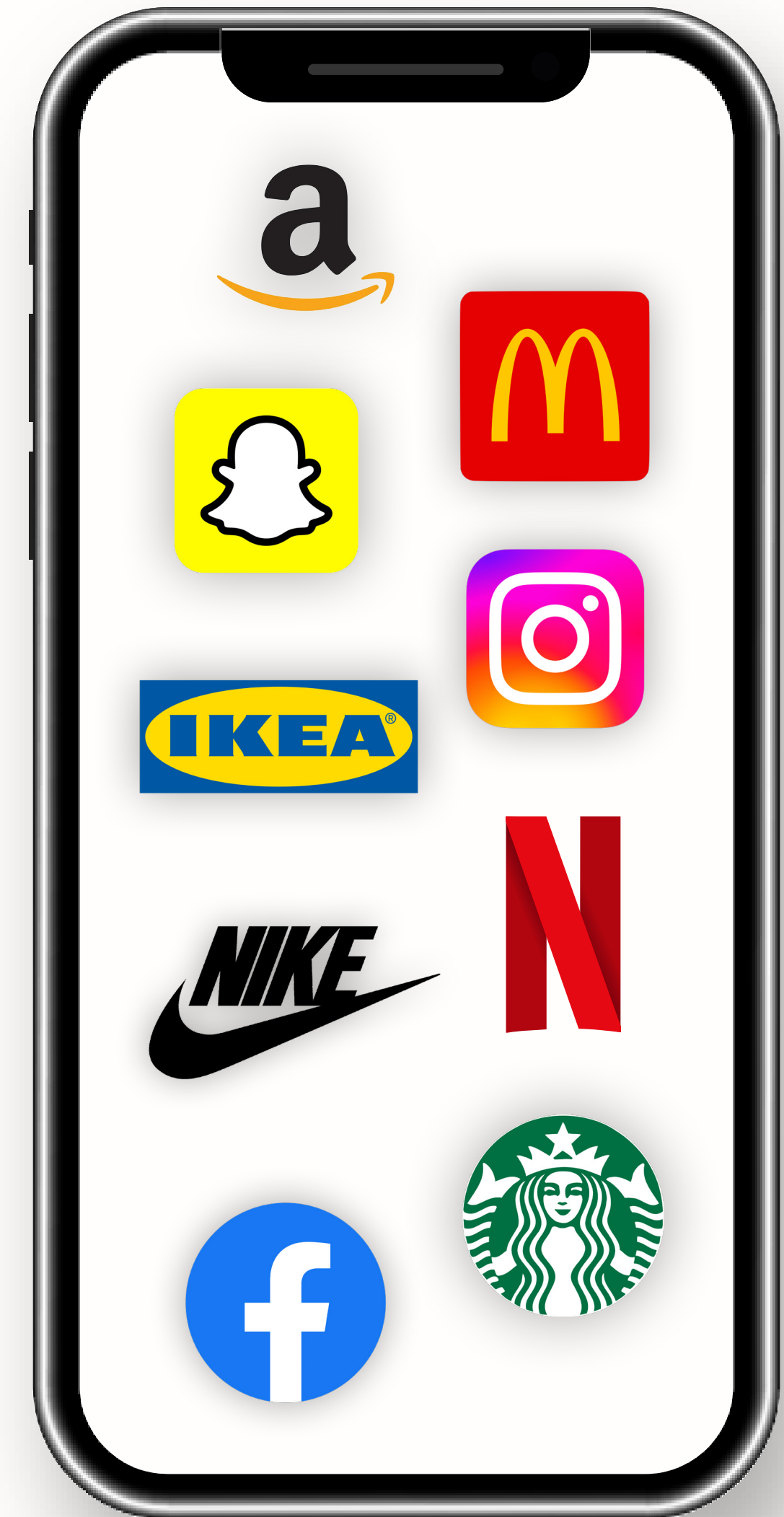


What is FOMO?

FOMO (Fear of Missing Out) was coined in **2004** by Patrick J. McGinnis to describe anxiety around missing social experiences as digital connectivity increased.

The term became mainstream with the rise of social media and was added to the Oxford English Dictionary in **2013**.

FOMO peaked around **2013–2014** and is now commonly used in marketing by major brands to drive urgency and exclusivity through **limited-time offers** and exclusive releases, and disappearing content.



Assumptions & Goals:

Gen Z may not strongly identify with the term FOMO, as it peaked in popularity during the **2010s**.

Despite this, Gen Z is highly connected through **technology and social media**.

The feeling of missing out likely remains, but may be expressed through **new language, behaviors, or trends**.

Understand how Gen Z **experiences and defines** feelings of missing out.

Determine whether they still use the term FOMO or have adopted **new language**.

Explore how social media influences feelings of **connection, exclusion, and anxiety**, and how they cope with that.

Identify whether **personality traits** and individual differences impact experiences with FOMO.

Interview Insights:

I interviewed **7 participants, ages 15–32**, across Gen Z and Millennials to understand how different generations experience FOMO, social connection, and digital culture.

Key Takeaways

- **Real-life exclusion has a greater emotional impact than digital exclusion**, though younger Gen Z is more sensitive to online visibility and urgency.
- **FOMO remains a relevant and widely recognized concept**, but its expression may be evolving among younger generations.
- **Personal goals, strong offline relationships, and emotional maturity** help reduce FOMO, while social comparison, life transitions, and constant online exposure tend to increase it.

Observations, Problem & Solution:

The Gen Z/Zillennials who were interviewed are all at **transitional moments in their lives**. And they all acknowledged that **real-life connections are valuable** and social media platforms often breed environments of comparison and spiraling.

Problem Statement

How might we help young adults feel more **grounded, confident, and connected** (instead of left behind) while navigating online spaces and scrolling on social media.

Possible Solution

A **self-guided app** designed to help young adults **reduce social comparison and FOMO** by focusing on **identity, personal growth, meaningful connection**, and **defining success on their own terms**.

Storyboard:

Kelvin starts in a cycle of **social comparison** and **doom scrolling**, feeling discouraged by others' achievements. Through Gatherly, he sets **personal goals**, finds support from a **like-minded community**, and gains confidence through **meaningful progress**. As he grows, he explores new interests, builds connections, and develops a stronger sense of identity.

Comparison → Doom Scrolling → Discovery → Goal Setting → Momentum → Identity Growth

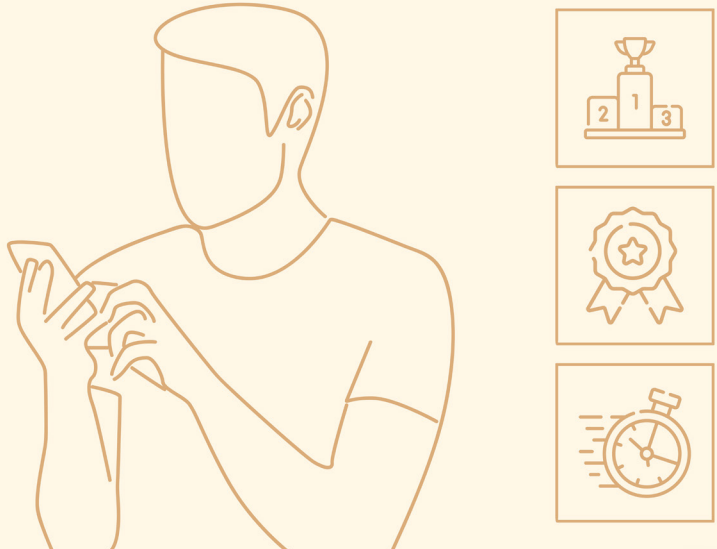
1. Comparison Loop

The user, Kelvin, is scrolling social media after the holiday break.

He comes across different posts from friends, highlighting their recent achievements.

Kelvin is reminded of his lack of momentum when it comes to his own cycling goals.

"Everyone else seems so far ahead..."



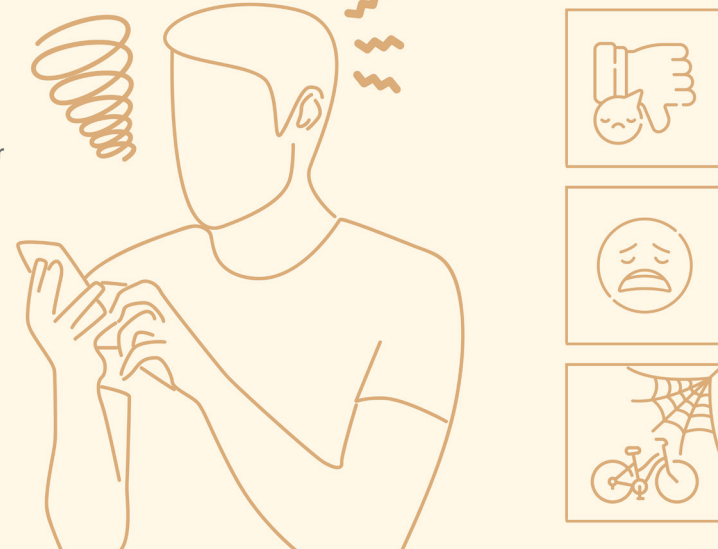
2. Doom Scrolling

Kelvin begins to spiral. He continuously scrolls his feed, hoping to feel better.

Seeing everyone else post their accomplishments convinces him that he's too far behind.

Unfortunately, he falls deeper into defeated demeanor. He's feeling very deflated and unmotivated.

"Maybe it's too late to start again..."

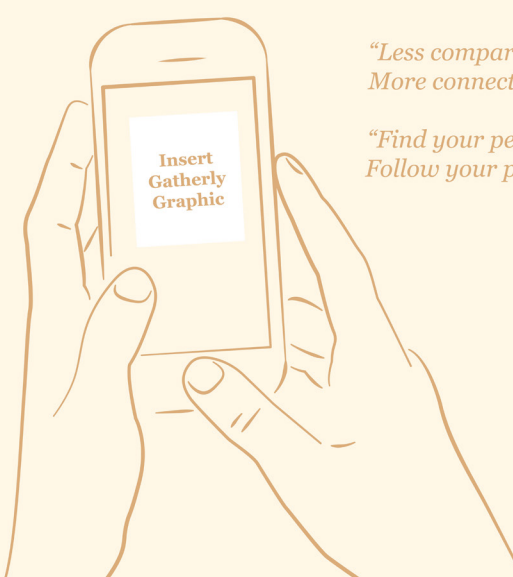


3. Discovery

Kelvin's friend notice that he's been very down lately. He suggests a change to get Kelvin out of his "funk" and "doom scrolling spiral."

He tells Kelvin about the new Gatherly app – a social media platform where users set goals for themselves and meet other like-minded people.

"Perhaps I'll give this new app a try..."



"Less comparison. More connection."

"Find your people. Follow your pace."

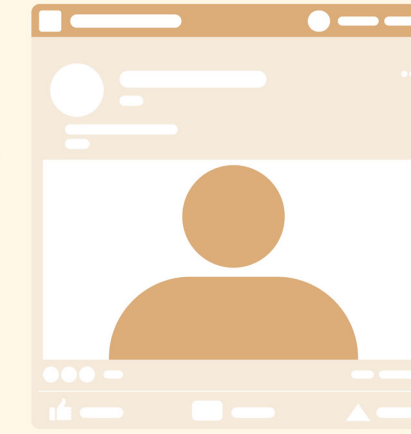
4. Setting the First Goal

Kelvin makes a new profile for his Gatherly account. He is asked to select his primary interests/hobbies.

After setting up his profile, he is asked to make a post, setting a small goal for himself.

Kelvin declares that he would like to get back into cycling and vows to do it at least once a week.

"Small steps are still progress..."



Users respond to Kelvin's post with applause, encouragement and appreciation tokens. Some reply offering advice and support.



5. Gaining Momentum

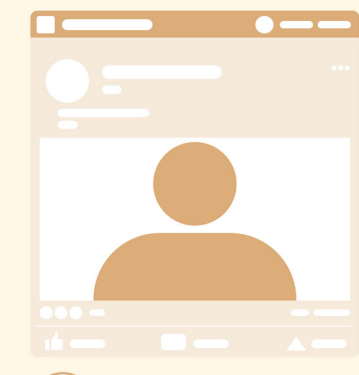
It has been one month since joining the Gatherly platform. Kelvin is making great progress towards his personal goals.

He's increased his biking from once a week to several times a week. He's increased his ride distance from 1 mile, to 3, and then 5!

He's met up with some other local cyclists on Gatherly. He's training for an upcoming race.

"Progress builds confidence..."





Consistency Badge

5-Mile Badge

6. Identity Expansion

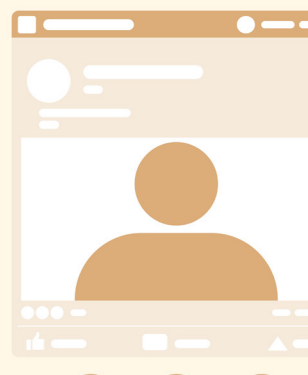
Feeling inspired by achieving his cycling goals, Kelvin branches out and joins other Gatherly communities.

He expresses an interest in cooking/baking. He joins a forum. He signs up for an online workshop.

He quickly makes new friends and connections in this new community. He adds a new skill to his repertoire.

"Where your path meets your people..."





• Inspiration

• Milestones

• Community

User Journey:

Discover

- User finds Gatherly while feeling discouraged from social comparison
- User sees ad for Gatherly either on TV, on streaming platforms, or on other Social Media sites.
- User is feeling: discouraged, deflated, unmotivated.



Onboard

- User creates a Gatherly profile. They are asked about initial interests/hobbies.
- User is able to complete the entire onboarding from their phone or on the desktop version.
- User is feeling: apprehensive.



Connect

- User is matched with different forums and communities that match their answers.
- User interacts with posts that align with their similar interests.
- User is feeling: hopeful and positive



Goals & Progress

- User is ready to set their first goal. The site encourages them to start small.
- The user is met with encouragement, praise and support from other users.
- The user is feeling: motivated.



Meet IRL

- User joins online workshops offered on the app.
- In the online spaces, User comes across local people who share the same interests.
- Local users meet up IRL to participate in their interests as a group.
- User is feeling: connected and supported.



Grow Identity

- User is very happy with the growth and progress they've made with their journey.
- User decides to expand their interests and begins exploring other Gatherly communities.
- User quickly makes friends in these new spaces on the platform.
- User is feeling: inspired and proud.



App Conceptulization & Research:

Why Gatherly Stands Out

Reduces comparison and rewards personal growth over popularity.

Encourages real-world engagement, meaningful connections, and identity development.

Makes progress visible through goals, badges, and milestones rather than likes and follower counts.

Gatherly's Differentiators

Identity & Growth First

Community + Real-World Connection

Achievement-Based Recognition

Calm & Safe Experience

Market Opportunity

“Gatherly” emphasizes connection and belonging with distinct, community-focused branding.

No competitor combines identity-building, communities, IRL meetups, skills, and career growth in one platform.

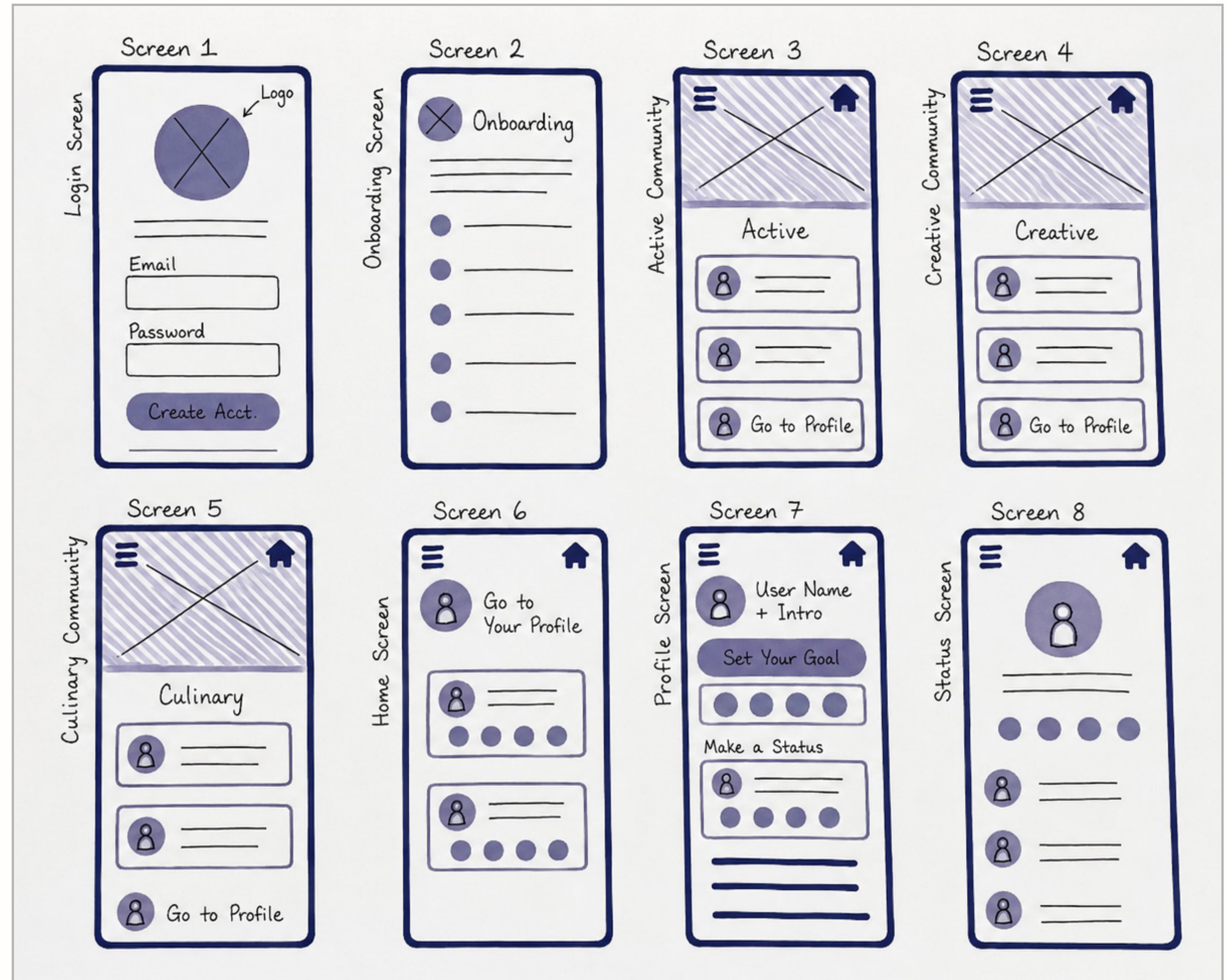
Common competitor challenges include notification overload, poor UX changes, moderation issues, and comparison-driven experiences.

Gatherly shifts social media from comparison to connection, helping young adults find their people, follow their pace, and grow into their most authentic selves.

Sketches:

Planned for **8 screens** to help take the user across the full journey, while also providing multiple paths to simulate user individuality.

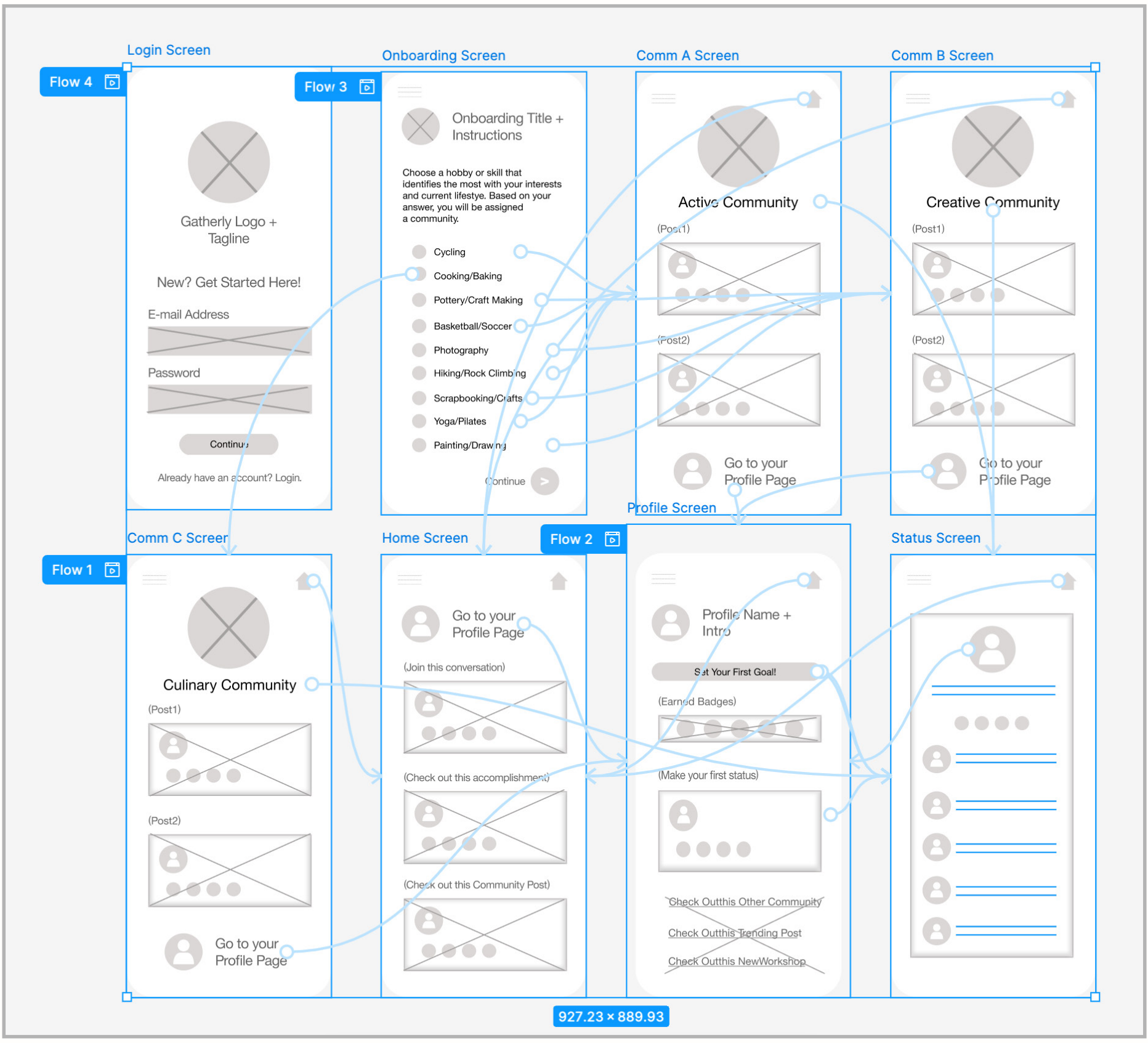
- Login
- Onboarding
- Active Community
- Creative Community
- Culinary Community
- Home
- Profile
- Status



Wireframes & Low-Fidelity Prototype:



Figma Prototype



Moodboard:

Final Logo Option



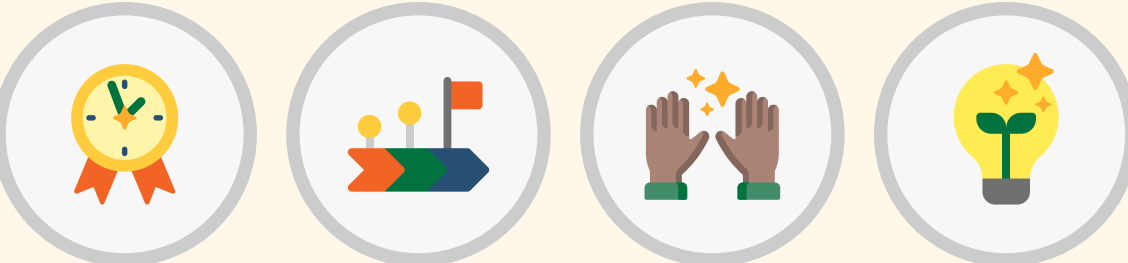
Icons

Reactions



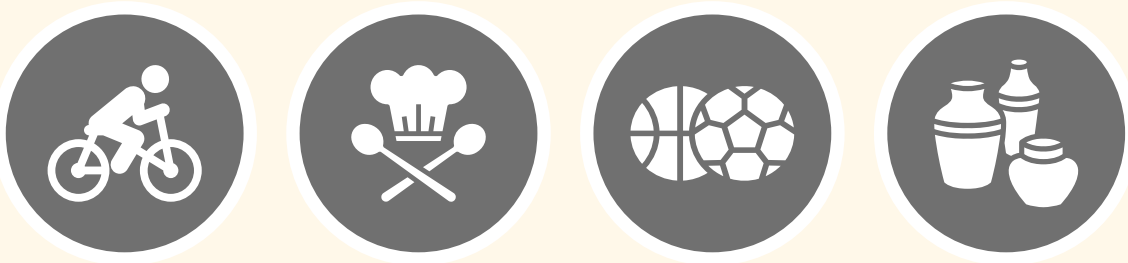
Support, Applaud, Hype, and Appreciation Tokens

Badges



Consistency, Milestone, Most-Hyped, and Curiosity

Hobbies



Cycling, Cooking/Baking, Sports, and Pottery

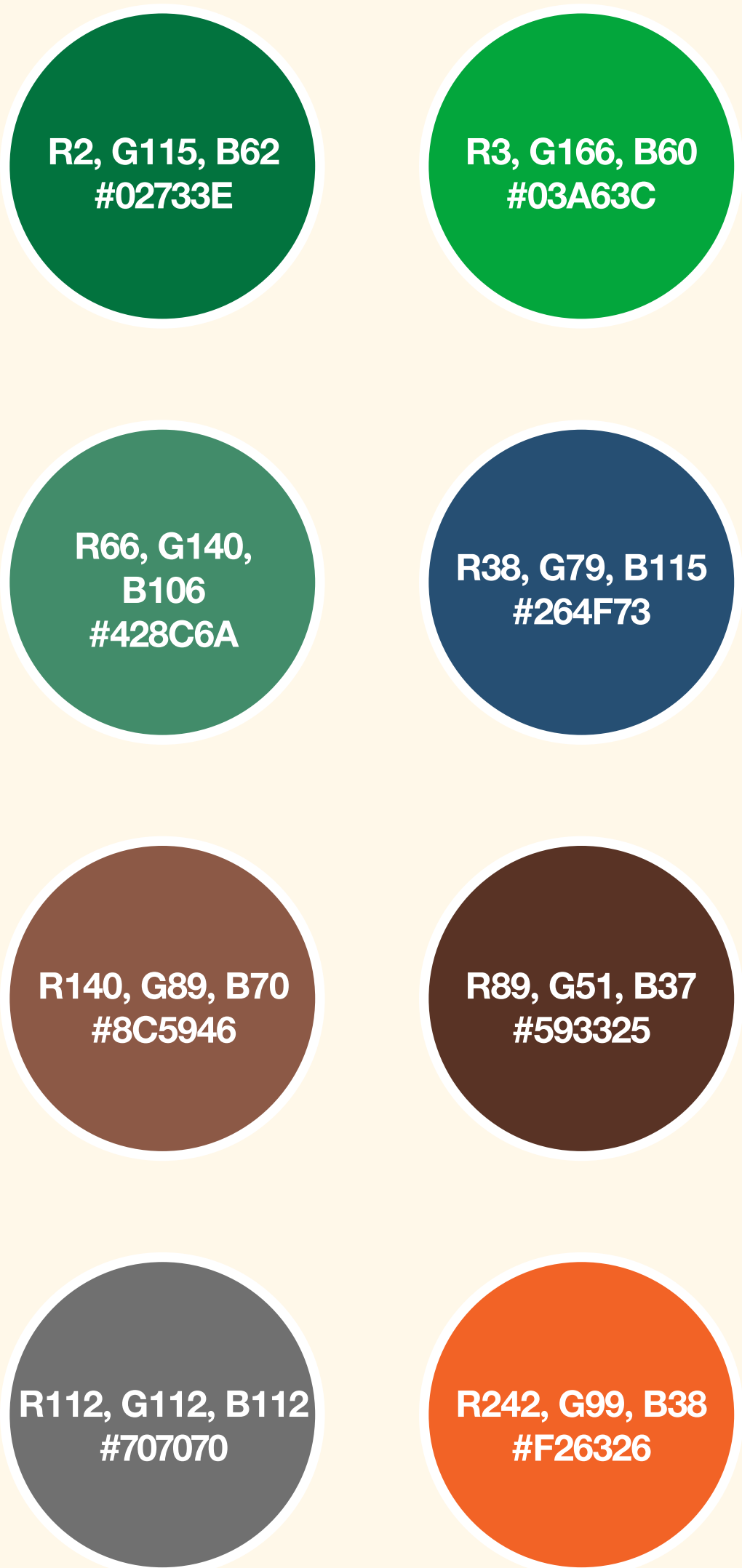
Stock Photos



Background :
R102, G102, B102 @ 5% Tint



Color Pallet



High-Fidelity Mockup:

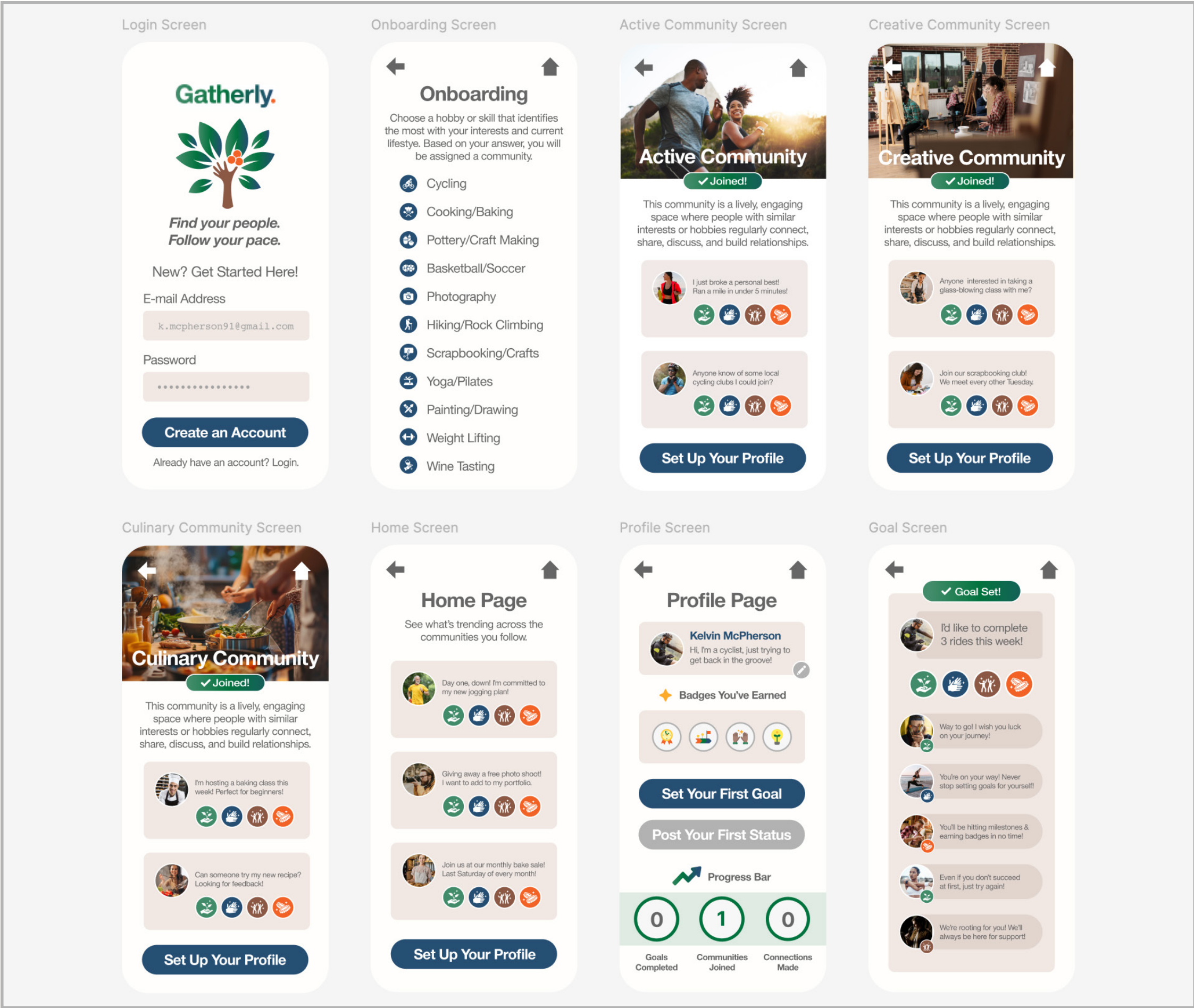
Final iterations went through a few, key changes which included:

- More prominent CTA throughout
- Dedicated back buttons for ease of navigation
- Completion statuses to show progress
- Placeholder text for elements that are not interactive, yet



High-Fidelity Prototype:

[Figma Prototype Link](#)



Practical Next Steps:

- 1 Prototype & test Phase 1 flows** (interest profile, groups, event RSVP/check-in, badges) with a small, mixed-age cohort (focus on early-20s + 18–24).
- 2 Design the moderation & safety model** (verification, event vetting, local lead roles).
- 3 Wire the token rules** (weekly cap, nontransferable growth points, simple badge logic).
- 4 Run 2–3 pilot partnerships with local workshops and community orgs** (validate attendance tracking and badge issuance).
- 5 Build KPIs for emotional outcomes** (self-reported groundedness, connectedness) and behavioral outcomes (event attendance, workshop completion, profile activity).

Conclusion:

This project explored how Gen Z and young adults experience FOMO in today's digital landscape and revealed that **social comparison, life transitions, and constant online visibility** often contribute to feelings of exclusion and self-doubt. Through user research, a clear opportunity emerged to create a platform that prioritizes **personal growth, meaningful connection, and real-world engagement** over popularity and comparison. Gatherly reimagines social media as a space where users can **set goals, discover communities, celebrate progress, and build identity** at their own pace. This transforms FOMO into confidence, belonging, and purpose.

Gatherly shifts social media from comparison to connection, helping young adults find their people, follow their pace, and grow into their most authentic selves.

